

GROWING FAST Beneficiaries of SeSTA with the goats they have reared, in Gova panchayat, Morigaon district, Assam

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WHY IT IS A GEM

- **SeSTA aims at economic development of the Northeast by building capabilities in rural areas**
- **It collectivises women and the marginalised to form self-help groups to start small businesses**
- **SeSTA has worked with 250,000 women farmers and families across 4,500 villages in 30 districts of Assam, Meghalaya, Tripura and Arunachal Pradesh**

"Many schemes exist, but we don't know how to access them. SeSTA helps us reach what is meant for us," she says. Tribini Bala Rai, associated with SeSTA since 2017, rears goats, keeps bees, cultivates black rice and manages vermicompost. She sold vermicompost worth Rs 90,000 just in 2024. "Low-interest loans and training made this possible," she says.

SeSTA's work has its challenges. Executive director Pradyut Bhattacharjee points to staffing and funding as persistent hurdles. Attracting committed professionals—particularly women—to physically demanding fieldwork is difficult. SeSTA tries to address this by offering stable employment, statutory benefits and long-term career pathways. Funding, too, is filtered. "We have turned down funds that compromise our ecological or social values," Bhattacharjee says. "Trust is our biggest challenge. We enter communities with new ideas, asking people to change long-held practices. That cannot be rushed. It has to be earned," he adds.

What works in Assam's flood-prone plains, SeSTA learned early, cannot be copied wholesale in Meghalaya's hills or Arunachal Pradesh's remote valleys. Every intervention is shaped by terrain, culture and local markets.

From its headquarters in Guwahati, SeSTA operates field offices across 60 development blocks. Among its 184 staff members, nearly half are women—a reflection of its priorities. Rather than replacing government systems, SeSTA works alongside them. It commits to years, not months, in each block—long enough for skills to transfer and institutions to stand on their own. ■